DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

2.3 Washington's Farewell Address

At the end of his first presidential term, George Washington wrote a goodbye letter to the American people. Then he ended up running for a second term. The letter—Washington's Farewell Address—was finally published in 1796, and it is an important American document.

When his eighth year as president was drawing to a close, Washington shared the letter with John Jay and Alexander Hamilton. The three men spent four months revising the letter, ensuring that Washington's ideas were crystal clear. Washington handwrote a clean copy of the finished letter—32 pages long—and addressed it to "Friends & Fellow-Citizens." It was published in the Philadelphia newspaper, *American Daily Advertiser,* on September 19, 1796. It was then printed in other newspapers throughout the country. Following his service as president of the United States, Washington moved back to Mount Vernon (shown in the photo), his home and plantation in Virginia. Washington grew up at Mount Vernon and had always dreamed of returning to his home life there. He lived at Mount Vernon until his death in 1799 and is buried there.



Mount Vernon, George Washington's home

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Historical document from Washington's Farewell Address, 1796

In this excerpt from his address, Washington tells Americans that they form one united nation. United, he tells them, they are stronger and more secure than they could ever be as separate individuals.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE Why does Washington urge people to be proud to be called Americans?

> The unity of government . . . is a main pillar in the edifice [structure] of your real independence, . . . of your tranquility at home, your peace abroad; of your safety; of your prosperity; of that very liberty which you so highly prize. The name of American, which belongs to you in your national capacity, must always exalt the just pride of patriotism.

DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Historical document from Washington's Farewell Address, 1796

Washington felt that political parties could pit one group of people against another, posing a threat to national unity. Here, he discusses the dangers of rival political parties.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE According to Washington, how might rival political parties affect a community?

> In contemplating the causes which may disturb our Union, it occurs as matter of serious concern that any ground should have been furnished for characterizing parties by geographical discriminations [differences], . . . whence [by which] designing men may endeavor to excite a belief that there is a real difference of local interests and views.

DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Historical document from Washington's Farewell Address, 1796

In 1796, France was at war with many other European countries, including Britain. As you've read, some Americans supported the French cause, while others supported Britain. In this excerpt, Washington warns against forming permanent alliances and argues for neutrality in all overseas affairs. He believes such alliances would open the country to foreign influence and unnecessary wars.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What did Washington's speech suggest about the policy the United States should follow with other nations?

> Nothing is more essential than that permanent, inveterate antipathies [harsh opposition] against particular nations, and passionate attachments for others, should be excluded and that, in place of them, just and amicable [friendly] feelings towards all should be cultivated. Excessive partiality for one foreign nation and excessive dislike of another cause those whom they actuate [fire up] to see danger only on one side, and serve to veil [cover up] . . . the influence on the other. The great rule of conduct for us in regard to foreign nations is in extending our commercial relations, to have with them as little political connection as possible.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about Washington's Farewell Address.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main idea that Washington expressed in each excerpt from his farewell address.
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: What factors did Washington fear could disrupt the unity and peace of the United States?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write an informative paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.